Wetland rescue

Until the 1980s, Feral Water Buffalo were allowed to graze in the Northern Territory's Kakadu National Park. They damaged native wildlife and their hard hooves compressed the ground in many places. After the Feral Water Buffalo had been removed from the area, a native grass called Mudja grew wildly and choked off wetlands. Local people had previously burned the Mudja grass so other plants could grow. Senior traditional owner Violet Lawson taught CSIRO Indigenous research officers Sandra McGregor – her daughter – and Peter Christophersen the burning method.

☞ **1** Decide which benefits apply to each action in the table below, and write the matching numbers in the right-hand column. There may be more than one for some actions, and some benefits may be used more than once.

Action timetable	**Benefits (numbers)**
Feral Water Buffalo allowed to graze in Kakadu up until 1980s	
Feral Water Buffalo removed from Kakadu	
Mudja grass grew and choked off wetland	none
CSIRO scientists consulted with Indigenous people and set up the burn timetable	
May to August burn-off. Paperbark forests and other woodland around wetlands burnt.	
September to December burn off. Wetland. Dead Mudja grass burnt and living grass killed.	
Later in season (before December 'big wet' arrives). Tuft burn off to get rid of dry grass tufts killed in earlier burns	
Wet season. There are now open water areas and ground available for growth.	

Benefits

1 Mudja kept down
2 wildlife recovers
3 ground softens
4 learn about burning
5 controls spread of burn-off
6 makes space for native plants
7 water lilies, wild rice and spike rushes grow
8 turtles and magpie geese thrive

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